metal that could stay sharp and hold a strong edge for longer than any other metal in the known world. Specialist blacksmiths worked for hours on each blade, layering sheets of steel together and forming a strong composite of high-carbon and low-carbon veneers. From this material, they created swords, knives, shields, spears, bows, arrowheads, cannons, and early types of handguns called matchlocks, blunderbusses, and flintlocks. Even their war elephants were equipped with steel blades, crafted to fit over the sawed-off stump of their tusks. Truly, theirs was a society built on the conquest and defense of warfare.

Elephant training was a very serious business to Babur and his military peers. Not only were the 2,000- to 5,000-kilogram (4,400- to 11,000-pound) elephants taught to trample the enemy beneath their immense feet, but Mughal officers trained the giant animals to use their bladed tusks in tandem with their agile trunks, effectively grabbing and ripping the enemy to pieces. Contemporary artists depict these elephants as confident killing machines, dressed with blades and protected by vast blankets of quilted leather or steel that sat up behind the head to protect the driver.

As Emperor Babur furthered his conquest of India, he brought hundreds of elephants that were trained in warfare and as confident in battle as the most experienced human soldier. The elephants were feared far and wide, featured in gruesome, full-color artworks in full armor with bloodied tusks and appendages, purposefully slicing through legions of enemy soldiers. A watercolor illustration attributed to the 16th-century artists Basawan and Chetar shows Akbar riding an elephant in pursuit of an enemy, another elephant by their side. They were an incredibly important part of Mughal warfare, ceremony, and overall culture—and would remain so throughout the ages in India.

In addition to artists, and the Persian language, the Mughal’s brought a love of beauty that would physically change the urban cityscapes and become part of India’s eternal identity.